PRELUDE XVIII

If a traditional illusion has made a slow movement of the second F minor Prelude, there is an opposite danger with its twin brother, this G♯ minor Prelude, which happens to put its most tempting running figures into the first bars, and to draw immediate attention to the broadest and most sonata-style aspects of the phrasing by the autograph *piano* and *forte* marks. These prove that the first two bars should, on the pianoforte, be given in a moderate *mezzo-forte;* nor should the marked *forte* exceed that. But the player should not risk a toboggan-run with his *tempo* until he has made sure that none of the melodic and rhythmic grace of bars 18-20, together with the subtle chromatic gradations of bars 23-24, have escaped his touch. The beautiful reading of E♮ in the bass of bar 6, according to the British Museum autograph, is carried on by Altnikol under Bach's own direction to the corresponding B♮ in bar 22. Some of Altnikol's other readings are likewise adopted here, as being evidently Bach's final decisions. In bars 44-45 one of the MSS. shows interesting evidence as to the evolution of *appoggiaturas* and the reasons for not writing them in full; the passage here reading as *repeated* quavers (two B sharps and E sharps), and the idea being, both in that and in the final form, rhythmic instead of ornamental. Note Bach's slurs where the detail is harmonically an *appoggiatura*. No reason can be found for the omission, in all MSS., for the *appoggiatura* in the latter half of bar 31. Of course, they are all to be played as quavers.

The dark left-hand chords in bars 47-49 should be slightly broken, like violoncello chords (compare bar 69 of the F minor Prelude.) The first theme, wherever it occurs, must be treated as an unbroken flow of semiquavers, joined imperceptibly by the two hands (bar 1, the link at bar 15, and bar 41). The double counterpoint in bars 8-11 must be equally expressive in both parts: nothing could be worse than a *staccato*-quaver notion or chopped-up phrasing that would reveal its ineptitude when the passage is inverted in bars 36-40. Elsewhere the quaver-basses, especially when disjunct, may be quite well detached.

Students who develop a healthy curiosity as to more MSS. authoritative readings than can be given here will find it well justified by consulting the editions of Bischoff, Kroll (Peters and *Bach-Gesellschaft*), with all their notes and appendices. No other piece in the Forty-eight has so many interesting alternative readings.

FUGUE XVIII

The counterpoint in bars 5-8, though not reproduced with the next entry, sheds an unexpected light on the tonality of the Subject, and is used several times later, both as Countersubject and in Episodes. It demands a singing tone. Episode 1, occupying bars 9-12 before the entry of the third voice, should, by its compressed modulations, warn the player against too quick a

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tempo for this large and thoughtful design. The new figures here outlined take more definite shape in the link-bars 17-18 and Episode 2, bars 23-32. After the Exposition there are no less than four entries of the Subject widely separated by Episodes, before the first section of this Fugue ends with a formal half-close on the dominant in bar 61. The deep bass entry in bar 55 should accordingly mark a broadly prepared climax, and the half-close will bear a slight *ritardando*, and even a pause, on the second quaver (Fx) in bar 61. After this, the player having taken a breath after the pause, a Second Subject is exposed in all three voices (treble, bar 61; middle, bar 66; bass, bar 71). The counterpoints, though derived in interesting ways from previous material, must be taken very lightly; the chromatic new theme is all-important, and itself indicates a very quiet tone, like all of its kind when given separate exposition. An extra entry in the treble (bar 79) leads to an Episode (derived from its rising portion) which, in the long line drawn by its bass from bar 85 onwards, indicates a *crescendo*, the culmination of which catches even the eye at the dominant pedal and the crowd of semiquaver detail about bars 90-96. And so indeed this section ends by breaking into the combination of First and Second Subject in a sonorous position (bar 97). The player should make the most of the different tone-colours produced simply by the five positions of the combination—viz., besides that of bar 97, the ringing soprano-tenor position at bar 103; the viola-violin *cantabile* colour at bar 111 (the only major-key entry in the whole Fugue); the deepest and most sonorous position of all (tenor-bass) at bar 125; and the close middle position with actually crossing parts, over a deep and primitive root-bass, at bar 135. The foundations of the final climax are to be laid by the bass in bar 128, where, on the fifth quaver, it takes up the second figure of the theme, which is imitated in a pile of sequences in two different octaves by the other parts, such canon in three octaves being a favourite means of climax with Bach. The shake given by Bach to the penultimate note of the Second Subject can be supplied wherever playable. It will have a turn at the end. It is a very necessary means of protecting the Second Subject from an undesigned resemblance to the occasional counterpoint of the first section. The *appoggiatura* in bar 142 (for once noted by Bach as a semiquaver) should be quite short, as printed here.

The *tempo* should give a leisurely impression of undisturbed movement, with a rather distinct second accent in the middle of the bar, which, however, should be absent in the Second Subject. There is no room for any touch but a *legato*.